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POETIC LIGHT
Arun Kolatkar (left) and Kamala Das

The Penguin Book of Indian Poets is a conversation between catastrophe and hope for a time when 'democracy and reality were under attack'

BOOKS

WHAT 'IS' INDIAN POETRY?

A milestone and a doorstopper, this ambitious anthology brings together 94 poets whom India can claim as its own

Any book that claims to anthologise 'Indian' literature, in a way, sets itself up for failure. What does it even mean for a piece of writing to be Indian? Is it the author's citizenship? Her manner of speech? Cultural references that bind her words to a place with rigid borders?

The Penguin Book of Indian Poets, edited by Jeet Thayil, is aware of these landmines. A beautiful compilation of Indian poetry in English from the 1950s to the present, it steels itself against its own grandiose title. Here is a book made of poets living and dead, those who migrated and even those who were born elsewhere. Among the 94 poets (49 of them women), we are forced to resist a shorthand for

Photographs by MADHU KAPPARATH